from 62 seats to 33, questions were raised about his leadership. Within the party, voices like deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya and state BJP chief Bhupendra Chaudhary criticised his alleged "over-reliance" on government officials, which they claimed had alienated grassroots workers. Adityanath's fortunes seemed to rebound in the November assembly bypolls—the BJP won in seven out of nine seats, while its ally Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) won one seat and the SP retained two. The turnaround bolstered Adityanath's position, but the Milkipur bypoll is being seen as a litmus test for his leadership. A victory here would be crucial to consolidating his authority ahead of 2027.

Adityanath himself has accorded the poll the utmost attention—over the past six months, he has visited Ayodhya over 20 times, overseeing the BJP campaign. On January 4, addressing party workers, he exuded confidence, citing the BJP's November triumph in Kundarki, a constituency with a 65 per cent Muslim population and considered an SP bastion. "If we can win Kundarki in the name of development, we can wrest Milkipur too," he said.

Stacked on top of the religion narrative, the BJP has striven to position Ayodhya as a "symbol of development". Its ground-level campaigns by party workers duly convey its development works and welfare schemes. To reach out to SC voters, the party has deployed several local Dalit leaders like Pushpendra Pasi, who has been appointed assembly seat convenor, and district general secretaries Radhey Shyam Tyagi and Shailendra Kori.

The unique context to the bypoll—its vacating MLA being the instrument of the BJP's humiliating loss in Faizabad—has made this more than a local contest. Winning Milkipur would help the BJP reclaim lost ground and reinforce the perception of recovery in UP. A win would also reinvigorate its cadre, while a loss could reignite internal dissent and questions about Yogi Adityanath's leadership. The ruling party in Uttar Pradesh is looking at Milkipur with hope, and some dread. ■

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